



Division Training Policy

DP002C

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1. Record of Changes

Revision	Date	Description Of Change
A	12/01/2022	Initial release.
B	04/29/2023	Creation of DICE program. Implementation of Rating Competency Exams.
C	02/16/2025	Major reformat and reorganization. Deletion of DICE. Removal of GCAP- and DP001-duplicative sections.

2. Policy Information

2.1 Purpose

To provide a standard for the operation of the VATUSA division Training Department and those of all subdivisions within. This policy governs the issuance of the S1, S2, S3, and C1 controller ratings and the I1 and I3 instructor ratings within VATUSA. Controller ratings may only be granted in accordance with this policy, except for the C3 rating.

2.2 Applicability

This policy applies to all members of the VATUSA division and all sub-divisions. It is for use on the VATSIM network only, and is **not** intended for real-world use.

2.3 Distribution

This policy shall be available on the VATUSA Website, under Policies & Downloads.

2.4 Cancellation

This policy cancels and replaces DP002, effective 08/13/2024.

2.5 Effective Date

This order is effective as of 02/16/2025.

2.6 Signatories



Brin Brody

Deputy Director Training Services

3. Subdivision Teachers

3.1 General

1. Subdivision teachers are designated for the purpose of providing student instruction.
2. The subdivision teacher roles listed in this section are the only VATUSA-recognized roles for the purpose of access control to VATUSA systems (e.g., VATUSA website, Discord). Subdivisions may designate their own supplemental training staff roles as appropriate, provided that these designations do not conflict with this policy, or any other VATUSA or VATSIM guidance.

3.2 Instructor

3.2.1 Duties and Responsibilities

1. Instructors are teachers who are authorized to conduct training, issue solo certifications, and conduct rating examinations for all controller ratings (S1, S2, S3, and C1).
2. Instructors serve at the discretion of the Deputy Director Training Services.
 - a. If assigned to a subdivision (holding instructor privileges there), instructors report directly to the subdivision's Training Administrator for all matters pertaining to student instruction within that subdivision.
 - b. Instructors holding privileges in multiple subdivisions report to each subdivision's Training Administrator separately, as appropriate and related to student instruction at each subdivision.
3. Instructors are specially designated by holding the I1 or I3 controller rating, except when holding a SUP or ADM rating as required for other network duties.
 - a. Holders of the I1 or I3 rating must maintain instructor privileges at their home subdivision. Instructor privileges may not be held at a subdivision other than a holder's home subdivision without the same designation at home, except as approved by the Deputy Director Training Services.

3.2.2 Eligibility

1. To be eligible for nomination as an instructor, a controller must:
 - a. Be a home controller at the subdivision submitting the nomination.
 - b. Hold a C1 or C3 controller rating (or have achieved either rating prior to holding a SUP or ADM rating as required for other network duties).
 - c. Hold all endorsements in the subdivision submitting the nomination.
 - d. Have not had any recent unprofessional activity or network suspensions.
 - i. Recency is defined at the discretion of the Deputy Director Training Services.
2. VATUSA may appoint instructors independently of the requirements established by 3.2.2.1 of this policy; subdivisions may not.

3.2.3 Nomination

1. A subdivision may nominate any controller meeting the requirements in 3.2.2.1 of this policy for the issuance of the instructor rating and associated privileges.
2. Subdivisions may nominate controllers as either a:
 - a. Probationary Instructor, who must complete the Probationary Instructor Program as defined by 3.2.4 of this policy; or a
 - b. Returning Instructor, who had previously completed the Probationary Instructor Program as defined by 3.2.4 of this policy, or who held the I1 or I3 rating prior to the establishment of the Probationary Instructor Program (identified by an I1 or I3 promotion with no accompanying log entry in the controller's VATUSA action log, prior to 01/01/2020).
 - i. Subdivisions may nominate controllers who qualify for a Returning Instructor appointment as a Probationary Instructor if they wish for the controller to complete the Probationary Instructor Program.
3. To nominate a controller, the subdivision Training Administrator shall advise the VATUSA Training Team, via email (training@vatusa.net), of their nomination. This nomination must include the controller's name, VATSIM ID, and the category of nomination (probationary or returning).

3.2.4 Probationary Instructor Program

1. Upon receipt of a Probationary Instructor nomination from a subdivision Training Administrator, the VATUSA Training Team will notify the nominee of the requirements of this program, provide the nominee with a link to the Probationary Instructor Review Form, and request that the nominee accept the nomination.
2. Upon acceptance of the nomination, the nominee will be made a Probationary Instructor, being issued the I1 rating and associated privileges at the nominating subdivision for a period of forty-five (45) days.
 - a. This probationary period may be extended to allow the subdivision or division more time to evaluate the Probationary Instructor, or to allow more time for the Probationary Instructor to complete program requirements.
 - b. Requests for an extension must be submitted via email (training@vatusa.net), and are approved at the discretion of the Deputy Director Training Services.
3. Before the end of the probationary period, the Probationary Instructor must:
 - a. Submit at least three training records for sessions completed in which the Probationary Instructor was the primary teacher.
 - b. Solicit, and ensure submission of, at least three Probationary Instructor Review Forms from students with whom the Probationary Instructor has completed a session.
 - i. All Probationary Instructor Review Forms must match with a training record submitted to satisfy 3.2.4.3(a) of this policy.
 - ii. Probationary Instructor Review Forms must be submitted independently by the student: Influence from the Probationary Instructor or subdivision is grounds for removal from the Probationary Instructor Program.
 - c. Conduct a rating examination for the S2, S3, or C1 rating while supervised by a non-probationary Instructor, and properly submit the appropriate Rating Review Form.
 - i. Except for S1 rating examinations, all rating examinations conducted by the Probationary Instructor during their probationary period must be supervised by a non-probationary Instructor, whose name must be indicated in the comments of the Rating Review Form.
 - ii. Unsupervised rating examinations are not permitted, except for S1 rating examinations.

4. At the end of the probationary period, the VATUSA Training Team will review all submitted documentation to determine suitability for making the Instructor rating permanent. If no concerns are identified, the subdivision Training Administrator will be notified and given an opportunity to refuse the Instructor. If the Instructor is accepted by the Training Administrator, the Probationary Instructor will be notified that they successfully completed the Program. A note will be entered into the Instructor's VATUSA action log reflecting this.
 - a. If the Training Administrator or VATUSA Training Team determine the Probationary Instructor is not suitable for release from the Probationary Instructor restrictions defined in 3.2.4.3(c)(i) of this policy, the Probationary Instructor's privileges will be removed, and they will be returned to their last controller rating (C1/C3), unless they hold a SUP or ADM rating.
5. If at any time during the probationary period VATUSA becomes aware of Probationary Instructor misconduct, including network suspensions, the probationary period will be immediately terminated, the Probationary Instructor's privileges will be removed, and they will be returned to their last controller rating (C1/C3), unless they hold a SUP or ADM rating.
6. Probationary Instructor privileges are not transferable between subdivisions: If at any time the Probationary Instructor elects to transfer to a different subdivision, the probationary period will be immediately terminated, the Probationary Instructor's privileges will be removed, and they will be returned to their last controller rating (C1/C3), unless they hold a SUP or ADM rating.

3.2.5 Removal

1. The VATUSA Training Team may remove an Instructor at any time, for any of the following reasons:
 - a. Violation of VATSIM or VATUSA policies
 - b. Removal from the division
 - c. Removal from a subdivision, or transfer to a different subdivision (unless prior permission is received from both affected subdivisions and VATUSA)
 - d. Awarded ratings not in accordance with this policy or the VATSIM Global Controller Administration Policy
 - e. Failure to maintain activity in a training capacity for at least 90 days
 - f. At the request of the subdivision, or the Instructor
 - g. Any other reason at the discretion of the Deputy Director Training Services

3.3 Mentor

1. Mentors are teachers who are authorized to conduct training, except as defined by 4.3.4.2(a).
2. Mentors serve at the discretion of one or more subdivision Training Administrators.
 - a. Mentors holding privileges in multiple subdivisions report to each subdivision's Training Administrator separately, as appropriate and related to student instruction at each subdivision.
3. Subdivision Training Administrators may appoint or remove Mentors at their discretion, except that Mentors may not have had any recent unprofessional activity or network suspensions at the time of their appointment.
 - a. Recency is defined at the discretion of the Training Administrator.
 - b. Additions or removals must be accompanied by an appropriate change in role on the VATUSA website.

4. Subdivision Training Programs

4.1 General

1. Subdivision training programs are established for the purpose of training in the following categories:
 - a. Rating training
 - b. Endorsement training
2. Training within VATUSA may be conducted through, but is not limited to, the following:
 - a. Student Self-study of relevant documentation
 - b. Lectures (either group or individual)
 - c. Interactive programs
 - d. Simulated traffic scenarios (sweatbox)
 - e. Monitored live network activities
 - i. Students who hold at least an S1 rating may be permitted to control a position requiring a rating one level higher than they currently hold under the supervision of an authorized teacher.
 - ii. A teacher conducting a live monitoring session shall not sign into an “underlying” position (e.g., a teacher on a _GND position monitoring a student on a _TWR position), or into a position at any other facility (e.g., a teacher on ABC_TWR monitoring a student on XYZ_GND).
 1. This provision is not intended to prohibit teachers operating an overlying position from monitoring an underlying position. Teachers using this methodology must exercise caution to ensure their attention is not divided to the point where they are unable to effectively monitor a student and provide instruction.
3. All subdivision training policy documents must be submitted via email (training@vatusa.net) for review and approval by the Deputy Director Training Services and must comply with all VATSIM and VATUSA policies. Documents must not be published until formally approved.

4. A training record must be submitted to the VATUSA website for every individual training session conducted under a subdivision training program.
 - a. Subdivisions may implement an integration from their website to automatically transmit training records to the VATUSA website. The teacher conducting the session is responsible for ensuring that these records are properly reflected on the VATUSA website.
 - b. Training records must provide, at least, a general overview of the topics covered, and feedback for the student, including areas for improvement.

4.2 Student Expectations

1. Students are expected to take an active role in their training. This means that students are expected to review all relevant material before attending training. Relevant material includes, but is not limited to:
 - i. VATUSA Academy Courses;
 - ii. Subdivision policies and procedures;
 - iii. Subdivision training materials;
 - iv. Sections of the FAA Order 7110.65 and other relevant Orders;
 - v. Materials specified in subdivision training policy; and
 - vi. Additional materials as directed by training staff.
2. Teachers are authorized to terminate any training session for which the student is unprepared. Such termination must be documented in a training record for the student.
 - a. Repeated unpreparedness may result in restrictions on student access to training, as defined by subdivision training policies.

4.3 Rating Training Programs

4.3.1 General

1. Rating training programs are established to train prospective controllers to proficiency in the ATC competencies established for each rating in the [VATUSA ATC Competencies](#) supplemental document.
2. Rating training programs consist of written content, written exams, classroom training, and simulated scenarios via Sweatbox, and conclude with a practical rating examination to verify proficiency in the established competencies. For added effectiveness, rating training programs should utilize other training methods, including those identified in 4.1.2 of this policy, as appropriate.
3. Rating training programs shall instruct and examine to a level of proficiency required to control unrestricted positions during normal traffic levels.
 - a. Enroute (C1) programs shall instruct and examine to a level of proficiency required to control normal traffic levels on the subdivision's designated Tier 2 enroute position.
4. All subdivisions shall define a rating training program for each rating in their subdivision training policy. This program should contain, or be accompanied by, one or more syllabi detailing specific lesson plans to be used by teachers.

4.3.2 VATUSA Academy Coursework

1. All subdivision rating training programs must require completion of the appropriate VATUSA Academy coursework and written examination prior to attempting the practical rating examination.
2. Students who hold, or have previously held, a certification to perform real-world air traffic control duties at a FAA or DOD facility may be exempt from completing VATUSA Academy coursework through completion of the appropriate Rating Competency Examination (RCE).
 - a. A real-world controller requesting an exemption under this section shall submit proof of their real world experience to the VATUSA Training Team, who will determine whether the student is eligible for an RCE exemption.
 - b. Real-world controllers who are exempt from Academy coursework are not exempt from practical training requirements, or subdivision theory training.

4.3.3 Solo Endorsements

1. Subdivision rating training programs may issue solo endorsements to students. A solo endorsement allows a student in training for a new rating to control a single position that requires a rating one level higher than their current rating (e.g., an S2 in training for S3 may be solo endorsed for one _APP position).
2. Solo endorsements may be issued for up to 45 days. Students may only hold one solo endorsement at any given time.
 - a. Solo endorsements may be extended by the Deputy Director Training Services for up to 90 days from the initial endorsement date. Subdivision Training Administrators requesting such an exemption must submit this request via email (training@vatusa.net).
 - b. Active solo endorsements may be cancelled prior to the end of the 45-day period under the following conditions, without notification to, or approval from, the VATUSA Training Team:
 - i. The student passes the appropriate rating examination.
 - ii. The student fails the appropriate rating examination, and it is the subdivision's judgement that they are no longer competent to control the position specified.
 - iii. The subdivision receives notice (e.g., via pilot-submitted feedback) that the student is no longer competent to control the position specified.
3. Solo endorsements may be issued by Instructors, or by Mentors if permitted by subdivision policy. The teacher entering the endorsement is ultimately responsible for the performance of the student while operating under the solo endorsement.
 - a. Subdivisions electing to enter solo endorsements via the VATUSA website API must maintain a record of which teacher authorized each solo endorsement, and must provide these records to the VATUSA Training Team upon request.

4.3.4 Rating Examinations

1. A rating examination is the final step to achieve a new rating. A rating examination consists of both a theoretical and practical assessment designed to ensure proficiency in the relevant competencies of a rating.
2. Rating examinations are required for the issuance of the S1, S2, S3, and C1 ratings.
 - a. S1 rating examinations may be conducted by an Instructor, or by a Mentor holding an S3 rating or higher.
 - b. S2, S3, and C1 rating examinations must be conducted by an Instructor.
3. Rating examinations must be conducted by a non-probationary Instructor, except as provided for by 3.2.4.3(c) of this policy.
 - a. Rating examinations must be conducted by a teacher who completed no more than 40% of the student's training for that rating, except when approved by the Deputy Director Training Services.
4. Upon completion of a rating examination, the Instructor conducting the examination must enter the appropriate Rating Review Form on the VATUSA website.
 - a. If the rating examination is completed satisfactorily, the Instructor must execute the appropriate promotion through the VATUSA website.
 - b. Except as noted in 4.3.4.2(a)(i) of this policy, or when otherwise authorized by the Deputy Director Training Services, Instructors are not permitted to enter Rating Review Forms, or to execute promotions, on behalf of other teachers. The Instructor who executes the promotion is ultimately responsible for the performance of the student while operating positions for which that rating is required.
 - i. Entering a Rating Review Form or executing a promotion on behalf of another teacher is grounds for revocation of Instructor privileges under 3.2.5 of this policy.

4.4 Endorsement Training Programs

4.4.1 General

1. In addition to their rating training program, subdivisions must define an endorsement training program for all Tier 1 (T1) and Tier 2 (T2) designated positions in their subdivision training policy. This program should contain, or be accompanied by, one or more syllabi detailing specific lesson plans to be used by teachers.
2. Subdivisions must not establish “dependencies” between endorsement training programs (e.g., ABC_GND must not be a prerequisite for the XYZ_GND endorsement).
 - a. This provision does not apply to positions that must be combined with other endorsement-required positions when not staffed (e.g., ABC_GND may be a prerequisite for the ABC_TWR endorsement).
 - b. This provision does not preclude a subdivision from establishing a standard/recommended flow in which some endorsements are completed before others, nor does it preclude a subdivision from encouraging controllers to pursue other endorsements (e.g., by assigning a “training” facility, for those subdivisions with multiple T1/T2 facilities) as a means of distributing training demand. However, a student must be permitted to train for their desired endorsement if requested.
 - i. Subdivisions are not compelled to provide immediate or otherwise expedited training for a student requesting a particular endorsement. Students should be advised of any anticipated delay at the time of their request.

4.4.2 Event Endorsements

1. Event endorsements are related to high traffic volume or special procedures utilized during events. Subdivisions may utilize event endorsements to determine which controllers are authorized to control positions during an event. Subdivisions using event endorsements must specify this in their subdivision training policy.
2. Subdivisions must define an endorsement training program for all event endorsements in their subdivision training policy. This program should contain, or be accompanied by, one or more syllabi detailing specific lesson plans to be used by teachers.
 - a. Scenarios used for assessing event endorsements shall simulate de-combined positions as would be realistic for an event and shall contain a volume of traffic that would be expected in an event. Event endorsements shall not be assessed top-down unless the associated positions are regularly staffed top-down during events.
3. When a subdivision chooses to implement event endorsements, each Tier 1 and Tier 2 endorsement must have a corresponding event endorsement. Unrestricted positions shall be grouped together into one endorsement per position type (i.e. Clearance Delivery, Ground, Local, Approach, and Enroute).
4. Subdivisions may require currency for event endorsements. Such currency requirements must not be more restrictive than controlling one event or completing one recurrent training session every 6 months.
5. Subdivisions choosing to use event endorsements shall display those endorsements on their subdivision website to, at least, all VATSIM-authenticated users.